

Giant otter

Pteronura brasiliensis

The world's largest otter is also one of the rarest—only a few thousand are thought to remain in the wild. Nicknamed the “river wolf,” this sinuous, web-footed, muscular member of the weasel family is one of South America's largest predators. It is fiercely territorial—which it has to be—in order to protect itself and its family from caimans, jaguars, pumas, and other threats in and around the river systems it calls home.

Scent warning

Giant otters live in groups of up to 20 animals: a male and female—which mate for life—and their offspring. The parents dig a den in riverbanks or under fallen logs and trample a section of the bank around it. All of the group scent-mark the perimeter of their territory with their anal glands to deter intruders. They fish in and patrol a section of the river around their den.

Giant otters are sociable—grooming, hunting, playing, and sleeping together. They have up to nine different vocalizations, from intense territorial screeches to chirps and whistles. Most cubs are born during the dry season, in litters of one to six, and are cared for by both parents and older siblings. Young otters stay with their families until they are at least two and a half years old.

- ↔ 3–5 ft (1–1.5 m)
- ⚖ 48–70 lb (22–32 kg)
- ⊗ Endangered
- 🐟 Fish, frogs, small caimans
- 🏠 🌳 🌿 🌾 🌻



▷ SINUOUS BODY

The giant otter's long, sinuous body, webbed feet, and flattened, wide-based tail mean it is well-adapted for diving and swimming, but its short limbs make it ungainly on land.



Hooded capuchin

Sapajus cay

Hooded capuchins are medium-sized, highly sociable monkeys, common in the tropical forests of the Amazon basin in South America. They get their name from the distinctive cap of dark fur at the top of their head, which resembles the hairstyle of a Capuchin monk.

Forest acrobats

These energetic and acrobatic monkeys move quickly through the lower and middle layers of the forest in groups of about 10–20, staying in touch with each other using a variety of birdlike, high-pitched calls.

Capuchins are highly intelligent and use a variety of tools to obtain food. In the lush swamps of the Pantanal, there is no shortage of palm nuts, which make up part of their diet. In northern populations, capuchins have been observed to crack open tough palm nuts by knocking one rock against another, but this behavior has yet to be confirmed in the south.

distinctive black cap



- ↔ 16–18 in (40–45 cm)
- ⚖ 7–8 lb (3–3.5 kg)
- ⊗ Common
- 🐟 Fruit, leaves, small animals
- 🏠 🌳 🌿 🌾 🌻



◁ FEEDING ON FRUIT

Clasping a prized piece of fruit, this hooded capuchin will eat it in the company of its troop.